



From Devotion to Monstrosity:
Grotesque Masculinity and the
Transformation of Ranvijay in
Animal by Sandeep Reddy Vanga

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Abstract

This paper explores the construction of grotesque masculinity in *Animal* (2023) through a critical analysis of its protagonist, Ranvijay Singh. Drawing upon the theoretical frameworks of Wolfgang Kayser, Mikhail Bakhtin, Francis S. Connelly, Philip Thomson, Michael Steig, Julia Kristeva, Sigmund Freud, and R. W. Connell, the study examines how excess, distortion, and psychological extremity shape Ranvijay's character. Tracing his transformation from a wounded child into a violent anti-hero, the paper argues that the grotesque functions both as an aesthetic device and a socio-cultural critique of hegemonic masculinity. By foregrounding bodily violence, emotional instability, and patriarchal obsession, the film exposes the destructive consequences of toxic masculine ideals in contemporary Indian society.

Keywords: Grotesque, Masculinity, Toxic Masculinity, Hindi Cinema, Psychoanalysis, Abjection, Hegemonic Masculinity, Violence, Body Politics, Alienation

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Introduction

Recent Hindi cinema has witnessed a growing fascination with morally ambiguous male protagonists whose identities are shaped by trauma, violence, and emotional repression. Films such as *Kabir Singh*, *Arjun Reddy*, and *Animal* foreground anti-heroes who challenge traditional ideals of morality while embodying disturbing manifestations of masculinity. Among these, *Animal* (2023) stands out for its unflinching portrayal of brutality, obsession, and psychological disintegration.

This paper examines Ranvijay Singh through the lens of the grotesque, an aesthetic mode that destabilizes conventional ideals of harmony, rationality, and beauty. His transformation from a devoted son into a violent anti-hero exemplifies the contradictions of hegemonic masculinity. By tracing his psychological and physical evolution, the study demonstrates how grotesque masculinity emerges as both cinematic spectacle and social critique, revealing the catastrophic consequences of patriarchal authority and emotional neglect.

Methodology

The research is grounded in an interdisciplinary theoretical framework that draws upon aesthetic, psychoanalytic, and gender-based perspectives. The grotesque is examined through the works of Wolfgang Kayser, Mikhail Bakhtin, Francis S. Connelly, Philip Thomson, and Michael Steig, who conceptualize it as a mode characterized by excess, alienation, transformation, and hybridity. Psychoanalytic insights from Sigmund Freud and Julia Kristeva provide tools to analyze repression, abjection, and the uncanny, while R. W. Connell's theory of hegemonic masculinity offers a critical lens for understanding patriarchal power structures. Together, these frameworks facilitate a nuanced interpretation of Ranvijay's transformation as both a psychological and socio-cultural phenomenon.

Defining the Grotesque

Etymology and Origins

The term "grotesque" originates from the Italian *grottesche*, referring to the fantastical decorative motifs discovered in the subterranean ruins of Nero's Golden Palace (*Domus Aurea*) in the late fifteenth century. These ornamental designs featured whimsical combinations of plants, mythical creatures, human figures, and architectural elements found in grotto-like chambers. Initially associated with this ornamental style, the grotesque blended organic and fantastical forms imaginatively. Over time, its meaning expanded into a major aesthetic and theoretical category in art and literature.

Michael Steig observes that "however customary it once may have been to use the term grotesque disparagingly... it seems clear that at present it is generally an honorific" (253). Once dismissed as bizarre, the grotesque is now recognized as a powerful artistic mode

capable of capturing estrangement in a world where the boundaries between reality and nightmare blur.

Theoretical Frameworks of the Grotesque: Estrangement, Excess, and Grotesque Masculinity

Wolfgang Kayser, in *The Grotesque in Art and Literature* (1957), defines the grotesque as an aesthetic that evokes radical alienation and estrangement. According to Kayser, the grotesque presents a world in which familiar elements suddenly appear strange, distorted, and threatening. Unlike fairy tales, where the supernatural remains comfortably detached from reality, the grotesque infiltrates the ordinary, unsettling the viewer's perception and destabilizing the boundaries between reality and nightmare. Kayser emphasizes that the grotesque cannot be separated from its psychological impact, as its power lies in the sense of disorientation and unease it generates in the observer. This concept finds a compelling cinematic manifestation in Ranvijay's transformation, where devotion mutates into monstrosity and familial love becomes a source of violence and terror, reflecting the Kayserian vision of estrangement.

Complementing Kayser's formulation, Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of grotesque realism in *Rabelais and His World* conceptualizes the grotesque as a mode that celebrates excess, transformation, and the materiality of the body. For Bakhtin, the grotesque body is exaggerated, unstable, and perpetually in a state of becoming, dissolving rigid boundaries between the refined and the crude, the sacred and the profane. It subverts hierarchical norms through distortion and hyperbole, revealing the instability of social and cultural ideals. Ranvijay's hyperbolic violence and emotional extremity exemplify Bakhtinian grotesque realism, as his body becomes both a spectacle of power and a site of degeneration. His exaggerated masculinity exposes the fragility and absurdity of patriarchal authority, rendering him simultaneously dominant and grotesque.

Expanding this theoretical framework, Francis S. Connelly, in *The Grotesque in Western Art and Culture* (2012), associates the grotesque with the "grotto," a liminal space symbolising an entrance into another world. He argues that the grotesque is best understood not by what it is but by what it does, describing it as an active force "more like a verb than a noun." Characterized by aberration, combination, and metamorphosis, the grotesque operates as a dynamic process that disrupts established boundaries and reshapes perception. Ranvijay's journey from innocence to monstrosity exemplifies this transformative process, embodying the grotesque as a state of perpetual becoming in which identity is constantly reshaped by violence, obsession, and psychological trauma.

Further enriching this discourse, Philip Thomson and Michael Steig highlight the grotesque's psychological complexity. Thomson emphasizes its aggressive and alienating qualities, arguing that its sudden shock functions as a disruptive force that transforms the familiar into something strange and disturbing, thereby producing profound alienation. Steig, in his

synthesis of grotesque theory, underscores its paradoxical nature, asserting that grotesque techniques both disguise and express repressed desires. This duality renders the grotesque simultaneously liberating and anxiety-inducing, allowing suppressed impulses to surface while intensifying psychological tension.

Ranvijay's character epitomises this paradox, as his violent excesses serve both as an expression of repressed longing for paternal approval and as a source of moral and emotional disintegration.

The grotesque finds further resonance in psychoanalytic and gender theory, particularly in the works of Julia Kristeva, Sigmund Freud, and R. W. Connell. Kristeva's concept of abjection elucidates how bodily fluids, violence, and decay disrupt the boundaries between self and other, confronting individuals with the fragility of identity and social order. The graphic brutality depicted in *Animal* exemplifies this abject dimension, evoking both repulsion and fascination. Freud's notion of the uncanny further illuminates Ranvijay's obsessive devotion to his father, revealing it as the return of repressed desires that transform love into violence. Meanwhile, Connell's theory of hegemonic masculinity provides a socio-cultural lens through which Ranvijay's character can be understood as an exaggerated embodiment of patriarchal ideals rooted in authority, aggression, and emotional repression. His hyper-masculine identity exposes the destructive consequences of toxic masculine norms, demonstrating how patriarchal conditioning engenders monstrosity rather than strength.

Together, these theoretical perspectives illuminate the psychological, aesthetic, and socio-cultural dimensions of grotesque masculinity. By synthesizing the insights of Kayser, Bakhtin, Connolly, Thomson, Steig, Kristeva, Freud, and Connell, the grotesque emerges as a dynamic and transformative force that destabilizes conventional notions of identity, morality, and power. Ranvijay's evolution in *Animal* thus stands as a powerful representation of grotesque masculinity, embodying alienation, excess, and psychological fragmentation while exposing the violent contradictions inherent in contemporary constructions of male authority.

Grotesque Masculinity and the Monstrous Becoming of Ranvijay Singh in *Animal*

In *Animal*, Ranvijay Singh's psychological and physical evolution embodies the trajectory of grotesque masculinity. His transformation unfolds through stages marked by excess, distortion, violence, and alienation, reflecting the grotesque as both an aesthetic mode and a socio-cultural critique. From childhood innocence to tragic monstrosity, Ranvijay's character reveals how patriarchal conditioning and emotional repression produce a fractured masculine identity.

The origins of this grotesque masculinity are evident in Ranvijay's childhood. The schoolyard incident, in which the young boy commits violence to defend his father's honor, foreshadows his eventual descent into brutality. Here, innocence merges with aggression, creating a grotesque fusion where filial devotion manifests as violence. This moment marks the

corruption of childhood and the internalization of patriarchal values, demonstrating how early emotional conditioning shapes masculine identity. Violence becomes synonymous with loyalty, establishing the foundation of his psychological transformation.

This formative experience is intensified by paternal neglect. Ranvijay's father remains emotionally distant, creating a void that profoundly shapes his son's psyche. His devotion gradually evolves into obsession, reflecting Sigmund Freud's theory of repression and Wolfgang Kayser's notion of estrangement. Deprived of affection yet desperate for approval, Ranvijay equates masculinity with brutality, seeking validation through acts of aggression. His psychological distortion exemplifies the grotesque transformation of love into violence, wherein the familiar bond between father and son becomes unsettling and destructive.

As Ranvijay matures, he performs an exaggerated version of masculinity rooted in dominance, control, and emotional repression. His rhetoric and behavior align with R. W. Connell's concept of hegemonic masculinity, yet they are amplified to grotesque proportions. Emotional vulnerability is suppressed, and masculinity becomes a spectacle of excess and aggression. In this hyperbolic performance, the grotesque exposes the instability and fragility of patriarchal ideals, revealing how exaggerated power ultimately masks insecurity and psychological instability.

The intrusion of grotesque masculinity into intimate relationships becomes evident in Ranvijay's marriage. His relationship with his wife transforms the domestic sphere into a site of psychological violence, characterized by emotional manipulation and patriarchal dominance. Rather than offering stability, the household becomes an arena of control and coercion. This distortion of intimacy underscores the corrosive effects of toxic masculinity, illustrating how patriarchal authority infiltrates and destabilizes personal relationships.

Ranvijay's violent encounters further intensify his grotesque transformation, turning his body into an instrument of destruction. Scenes of bloodshed and mutilation evoke Julia Kristeva's concept of abjection, confronting viewers with the fragility of civilization and the collapse of moral boundaries. The spectacle of bodily violence destabilizes distinctions between the human and the monstrous, producing both revulsion and fascination. In this context, the grotesque body emerges as a site where brutality and vulnerability coexist, embodying the tensions inherent in hyper-masculine identity.

The film's stylized action sequences also depict violence as mechanized and industrialized, reflecting modern alienation. The fusion of man and machine reduces masculinity to systematic brutality, suggesting emotional dehumanization. This mechanized masculinity underscores the erosion of empathy and individuality, presenting violence as impersonal, calculated, and relentless.

The grotesque thus extends beyond the physical body to encompass technological and ideological transformations, highlighting the dehumanizing effects of modern power

structures.

Ranvijay's confrontation with his adversaries introduces another dimension of the grotesque through the motif of the double. His antagonists mirror his own savagery, embodying Freud's concept of the uncanny. This doubling exposes the cyclical logic of revenge and reveals the self-destructive nature of hyper-masculinity. By confronting reflections of his own brutality, Ranvijay is forced to confront the monstrous aspects of his identity, illustrating the grotesque collapse of moral and psychological boundaries.

The illusion of patriarchal authority ultimately disintegrates with the vulnerability of Ranvijay's father. The once-invincible patriarch is revealed as fragile and mortal, destabilizing Ranvijay's identity. This moment exposes the hollowness of the ideals he has internalized, revealing masculine authority as an illusion. The grotesque irony lies in the warrior's regression into a grieving child, underscoring the psychological fragility concealed beneath his violent exterior.

By the film's conclusion, Ranvijay emerges as a tragic grotesque hero, embodying grotesque masculinity in its fullest form. Simultaneously powerful and self-destructive, he becomes both perpetrator and victim of patriarchal ideology. His emotional isolation, moral disintegration, and psychological fragmentation illustrate the catastrophic consequences of toxic devotion and repressed vulnerability. His transformation exemplifies Francis S. Connelly's notion of the grotesque as a dynamic process of becoming, wherein identity remains perpetually unstable and in flux.

Seen through this lens, Ranvijay's body functions as a symbolic site of meaning, reflecting successive stages of grotesque transformation. His childhood is marked by violent loyalty and the corruption of innocence; adolescence by hyper-masculine ideology and excess; adulthood by brutal dominance and bodily violence; marriage by emotional cruelty and psychological distortion; warfare by mechanized brutality and abjection; and the climax by estrangement and fragmentation. Ultimately, the narrative culminates in emotional ruin, establishing Ranvijay as a tragic embodiment of the grotesque.

Beyond its character study, *Animal* operates as a powerful social critique of contemporary patriarchal structures. The film exposes how emotional repression breeds violence, how patriarchal authority distorts male identity, and how hyper-masculinity legitimizes brutality. It demonstrates how devotion can devolve into obsession and how the relentless pursuit of power results in alienation and moral decay. In this sense, Ranvijay emerges not merely as a cinematic figure but as a cultural symptom, reflecting broader anxieties surrounding masculinity in modern Indian society.

In conclusion, *Animal* offers a profound exploration of grotesque masculinity through the character of Ranvijay Singh. His evolution from a devoted son into a violent anti-hero exemplifies the destructive consequences of patriarchal conditioning and hegemonic masculine ideals. Through excess, distortion, and psychological extremity, the film exposes

the fragility and contradictions inherent in modern masculinity. Drawing upon the theoretical insights of Bakhtin, Kayser, Connelly, Steig, Thomson, Freud, Kristeva, and Connell, the grotesque emerges as both an aesthetic mode and a critical lens. Ranvijay stands as a tragic embodiment of grotesque masculinity, simultaneously monstrous and human, compelling audiences to confront the unsettling realities embedded within contemporary constructions of male identity.

Conclusion

Animal offers a profound and unsettling exploration of grotesque masculinity through the character of Ranvijay Singh. His evolution from a devoted son into a violent anti-hero exemplifies the destructive consequences of patriarchal conditioning and hegemonic masculine ideals. Marked by excess, distortion, and psychological extremity, Ranvijay's trajectory exposes the fragility, contradictions, and inherent instability of modern constructions of masculinity. His transformation reveals how emotional neglect, obsessive devotion, and the relentless pursuit of patriarchal validation culminate in moral disintegration and existential alienation.

By drawing upon the theoretical insights of Mikhail Bakhtin, Wolfgang Kayser, Francis S. Connelly, Michael Steig, Philip Thomson, Sigmund Freud, Julia Kristeva, and R. W. Connell, this study demonstrates that the grotesque operates simultaneously as an aesthetic mode and a critical lens. It illuminates the dynamics of excess, estrangement, abjection, repression, and hegemonic power embedded within contemporary cinematic representations of male identity. Through its fusion of brutality and vulnerability, the grotesque destabilizes conventional ideals of heroism and exposes the monstrous potential concealed within socially sanctioned notions of masculinity.

Ranvijay emerges as a tragic embodiment of grotesque masculinity, at once monstrous and human, powerful yet profoundly fractured. He is not merely an individual character but a cultural symptom, reflecting deeper anxieties surrounding patriarchy, violence, and emotional repression in modern Indian society. His narrative compels audiences to confront the unsettling reality that the monstrous is not external to humanity but resides within its own structures of power and desire.

Ultimately, *Animal* transcends the boundaries of conventional cinematic storytelling to serve as a disturbing meditation on devotion, dominance, and degeneration. It reveals that when masculinity is forged through violence and sustained by patriarchal obsession, it collapses into grotesque self-destruction. In this collapse lies the film's enduring significance: a stark reminder that the pursuit of absolute power often culminates not in glory, but in alienation, ruin, and the haunting remnants of a fractured humanity.

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